We won the toss at the Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bangalore and opted to bat first. I used my trusted old bat and managed to hit a few boundaries. However, most of them were deflections behind the wicket and it was only when I tried to play a square cut off Ajmal Shahzad that I realized something was wrong. It was a full-blooded stroke but the ball did not travel to the fielder as fast as it should have. It was time to retire the old bat and call for the new one I had been knocking in. While I felt a little sad sending the old bat back to the pavilion, I did score a century with the new one – though I ended up breaking it in the quarter-final against Australia.

I have always enjoyed playing in Bangalore. I began cautiously and with Sehwag in full flow I was content to anchor the innings, but I decided to push the accelerator when Viru was dismissed for 35. Graeme Swann was England's leading spinner and I hit him for consecutive sixes at the start of his second spell, turning the momentum in our favour. I was finally out for 120 and, with fifties from Gambhir and Yuvi, we made 338 in our fifty overs.

England were brilliant in reply and also benefited from the very heavy dew, which meant our spinners had been rendered ineffective. In conditions of heavy dew the ball just skids on to the bat, something England were to encounter in their match against Ireland at Bangalore. (The Irish, despite losing five wickets cheaply, managed to get home, with Kevin O'Brien scoring a very good hundred.) Against us, Andrew Strauss played one of his best ever one-day innings, making 158, and he almost took England to victory before Zaheer pulled it back for us with a superb second spell, taking three wickets for just 11. The match finally ended in a tie, and it was a terrific advertisement for the game. A total of 676 runs were scored and still the two sides could not be separated. The fans loved the contest and the World Cup had captured the imagination of the cricket-playing world.

It was immediately after this match that talk of us winning the title started in the digital world and slowly the messages started reaching us in the dressing room. These discussions were based not just on our on-field performances. Someone had pointed out that every time Dhoni had been involved in a tie in a multi-nation competition, he had ended up winning the title. This had been the case in the World Twenty20 in 2007 (the India–Pakistan game was tied before India won in a bowl-out), in